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题目：How Influencer Source Credibility Shape Malaysian Consumers' Purchase Intention Toward Chinese Cross Border E-Commerce Brands

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网红来源可信度如何影响马来西亚消费者对中国跨境电商品牌的购买意向

摘要：本研究旨在探讨网红特征对消费者购买意向的影响，以中国跨境电商品牌为研究背景。研究重点分析网红专业性、可信度与吸引力对品牌信任与品牌态度的影响，并进一步探讨其对购买意向的作用，同时检验不确定性规避的调节作用。本研究采用定量研究方法，通过在线问卷收集数据，共获得 221 份问卷，其中 201 份为有效样本。数据分析采用 SmartPLS 软件进行偏最小二乘结构方程模型（PLS-SEM）分析。研究结果表明，网红专业性与可信度对品牌信任具有显著正向影响，同时网红专业性也显著影响品牌态度。然而，网红吸引力对品牌态度的影响不显著。此外，品牌信任与品牌态度均对购买意向产生显著正向影响，其中品牌态度的影响更为显著。不确定性规避在本研究中未表现出显著的直接或调节作用。总体而言，本研究强调了网红可信度及品牌相关因素在影响消费者购买意向中的重要作用，并为企业与营销人员制定跨境电商品牌的网红营销策略提供了实践参考。

关键词：网红来源可信度，网红专业性，网红可信度，品牌信任，购买意向

How Influencer Source Credibility Shapes Malaysian Consumers' Purchase Intention Toward Chinese Cross Border E-Commerce Brand

Abstract: This study investigates the influence of influencer source credibility on Malaysian consumers' purchase intention toward Chinese cross-border e-commerce brands. Specifically, the study examines the effects of influencer expertise, trustworthiness, and attractiveness on brand trust and brand attitude, and subsequently on purchase intention. In addition, the moderating role of uncertainty avoidance is also explored. A quantitative research approach was employed, and data were collected through an online questionnaire. A total of 221 responses were obtained, of which 201 valid responses were retained for analysis. The data were analyzed using Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) with SmartPLS. The findings reveal that influencer expertise and trustworthiness have significant positive effects on brand trust, while influencer expertise also significantly influences brand attitude. However, influencer attractiveness does not have a significant impact on brand attitude. Furthermore, both brand trust and brand attitude significantly affect purchase intention, with brand attitude demonstrating a stronger effect. In contrast, uncertainty avoidance does not show a significant direct or moderating effect. Overall, the results highlight the importance of influencer credibility and brand-related factors in shaping consumer purchase intention. The study provides practical implications for businesses and marketers in designing effective influencer marketing strategies for Chinese cross-border e-commerce brands.

Keywords: influencer source credibility, influencer expertise, influencer trustworthiness, brand trust, purchase intention

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Chapter 1 Introduction

1.1 Introduction

Recently, digital technology and social media have changed how companies advertise and talk to customers. Platforms like Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube allow businesses to easily reach people through influencer marketing. Social media influencers are people who can change how their followers think and act through the content they share (Freberg et al., 2011). Because these influencers build close bonds with their viewers, people often see their suggestions as more authentic and trustworthy than normal advertisements.

As this type of marketing grows, many companies partner with influencers to help sell their products. Past research shows that an influencer's trustworthiness is very important in how customers react to ads. People are more likely to believe information if it comes from a reliable source (Hovland & Weiss, 1951). Furthermore, this reliability is based on three main traits: how much the person knows, how honest they are, and how appealing they are (Ohanian, 1990). Marketers frequently use these three traits to judge if a spokesperson is effective.

At the same time, the rise of international online shopping has created new chances for global trade. Shoppers can now easily buy items from other countries online. Chinese online stores have quickly grown worldwide, including in Southeast Asia. However, buying from foreign brands can make shoppers feel unsure because they cannot see or touch the products before buying them (Bao, 2022). Therefore, shoppers often look to outside help, like social media influencers and online reviews, to judge foreign products.

Influencers help lower this uncertainty by sharing product details and their own personal experiences. Research shows that a reliable influencer can strongly affect how shoppers view a brand and whether they want to buy from it (Weismueller et al., 2020). When shoppers trust an influencer, they usually form a better opinion of the brand the influencer promotes. This opinion is based on what the shopper thinks and feels about the brand (Keller, 1993). Likewise, trust is a key part of buying decisions because people prefer to buy from brands they find reliable (Chaudhuri & Holbrook, 2001).

In addition, culture can affect how people shop. One cultural factor is "uncertainty avoidance," which describes how much people dislike unknown or unclear situations (Hofstede, 2001). Shoppers who strongly dislike uncertainty may depend more on

trusted information before buying. This is especially true for international online shopping, where the risk of making a bad purchase feels higher.

Even though many studies have looked at influencer marketing, very few have focused on how an influencer's reliability affects whether Malaysian shoppers want to buy from Chinese online brands. Therefore, this study aims to explore the connections between an influencer's trustworthiness, brand trust, brand opinion, and the desire to buy. It will also look at how a shopper's dislike of uncertainty affects these connections.

1.2 Research Objective

The main objective of this study is to examine the impact of influencer information source credibility on Malaysian consumers' purchase intentions towards Chinese brands via cross-border e-commerce.

To achieve this objective, the following specific research objectives have been identified:

1. To examine the effect of influencer trustworthiness on brand trust.
2. To examine the effect of influencer expertise on brand trust.
3. To examine the effect of influencer expertise on brand attitude.
4. To examine the effect of influencer attractiveness on brand attitude.
5. To examine the effect of brand trust on purchase intention.
6. To examine the effect of brand attitude on purchase intention.
7. To examine the moderating effect of uncertainty avoidance on the relationship between brand trust and purchase intention.

1.3 Research Question

According to the research objectives, This study aims to answer several important questions regarding the influence of influencer credibility on the purchase intentions of Malaysian customers towards Chinese brands in cross-border e-commerce.

The research questions have been formulated to examine the relationships between influencer credibility, brand trust, brand attitude and purchase intention.

The research questions for this study are as follows:

1. Does the influencer's trustworthiness significantly affect trust in the brand?
2. Does the influencer's expertise significantly affect trust in the brand?
3. Does the influencer's expertise significantly affect brand attitude?

4. Does the influencer's attractiveness significantly affect brand attitude?
5. Does trust in the brand significantly affect customers' purchase intentions?
6. Does an individual's attitude towards the brand significantly affect their purchase intentions?
7. Does the avoidance of uncertainty hinder the relationship between brand trust and purchase intentions?

These research questions provide the study with a clear focus and serve as a basis for formulating research hypotheses and conducting case-based analysis.

1.4 Research Significance

1.4.1 Theoretical Significance

This research adds to what we already know about influencer marketing and how shoppers act. First, past research has looked at how a reliable influencer changes what people think and buy on social media (Freberg et al., 2011; Weismueller et al., 2020). However, very few studies have looked at this specifically for international online shopping.

Second, the Source Credibility Theory suggests that a trustworthy speaker can change how an audience feels and acts (Hovland & Weiss, 1951). Even so, older studies usually only looked at the direct link between a trusted influencer and the desire to buy. This study goes further by exploring how brand trust and brand opinion act as connecting links between the influencer and the final purchase. Trust and opinion are key parts of how a shopper makes a decision (Chaudhuri & Holbrook, 2001; Keller, 1993).

Finally, this study includes the idea of "uncertainty avoidance" from Hofstede’s cultural theory (Hofstede, 2001). By looking at how a shopper's dislike of risk affects these connections, this research helps explain how culture changes a person's desire to buy things from other countries online.

1.4.2 Practical Significance

Along with its academic value, this study offers useful advice for businesses. As social media grows, companies depend more on influencers to advertise their products. Knowing how a reliable influencer changes how shoppers think and act can help businesses create better marketing plans.

For Chinese online stores wanting to grow in countries like Malaysia, influencers can be a great way to build brand awareness and trust. Because shoppers often feel unsure when buying foreign goods, reliable influencers can offer trustworthy details and lower the fear of making a bad choice (Bao, 2022).

Furthermore, this study can help marketers choose the right influencers. It points out the traits shoppers value most, such as knowledge, honesty, and appeal (Ohanian, 1990). By working with these trusted influencers, companies can improve how people view their brand and make them more likely to buy. Therefore, this research gives helpful ideas to businesses wanting to improve their influencer marketing for international online sales.

Chapter 2 Literature Review

2.1 Introduction

This chapter looks at past research on how online personalities promote products, how much people trust them, and how shoppers behave when buying items from other countries. The main goal is to build a solid background for this study and clearly explain the core ideas we are looking at.

As social media continues to grow, businesses increasingly rely on popular online figures to advertise their goods. These individuals can easily shape what their followers think and do online (Freberg et al., 2011). Because they have such a strong connection with their audience, many brands team up with them to help sell products.

At the same time, international online shopping has made it much easier for people to buy things from foreign markets. However, buying from unknown foreign brands can make shoppers nervous about whether the products are real and of good quality (Bao et al., 2022). In these cases, trusted online figures can help shoppers feel more confident by sharing helpful details and giving their personal recommendations.

To bring this all together, this chapter explores previous studies on several key topics:

- Trust in online figures: How reliable and believable these personalities are to their audience.
- Brand views: How consumers build trust and form opinions about a specific brand.
- Buying habits: How willing people are to actually make a purchase.
- Handling risk: How shoppers try to avoid uncertainty when spending their money.

Together, these ideas help explain the main focus of this research: how trusting an online personality affects whether Malaysian shoppers are willing to buy from Chinese online brands.

2.2 Influencer Marketing in Cross-Border E-Commerce

In today's digital world, forming partnerships with popular online influencers is a very common form of advertising. As platforms such as Instagram, TikTok and YouTube grow in popularity, these influencers have a significant impact on people's purchasing decisions. They often share product reviews, demonstrate how products

work, and talk about their personal experiences. This helps consumers form a much clearer picture of products before spending their money.

Compared to traditional advertising, product promotion by online personalities often appears more authentic and trustworthy. These individuals usually build strong connections with their audience by regularly posting content and engaging with them. Thanks to this connection, followers often view them as reliable sources of information when making purchasing decisions (Freberg et al., 2011).

When shopping in other countries, the role of these online influencers becomes even more important. People buying products from foreign brands often face significant uncertainty. They may be concerned about product quality, authenticity or the reliability of delivery (Bao et al., 2022). Trustworthy online influencers can help allay these concerns by sharing their practical experiences and genuine reviews of the products.

As a result, collaborating with online influencers is a highly effective way for companies to bring their brands to international markets, particularly when selling directly to overseas customers.

Influencer marketing has been widely recognized as an effective strategy in shaping consumer perceptions and purchase behavior in digital environments (De Veirman et al., 2017; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020). These studies suggest that influencers play a significant role in influencing consumer attitudes through content engagement and perceived authenticity.

2.3 Source Credibility Theory

Source Credibility Theory explains how the credibility of a communication source influences the effectiveness of communication. The theory was first introduced by Hovland and Weiss (1951), who suggested that the persuasiveness of a message depends largely on the credibility of the information source.

According to this theory, individuals are more likely to accept information from sources they perceive as credible. In marketing contexts, credible sources are more effective in influencing consumer attitudes and behaviors.

In the context of influencer marketing, influencers serve as communication sources who deliver marketing messages to consumers through social media platforms. When consumers perceive influencers as credible, they are more likely to trust the information provided by the influencers and develop positive attitudes toward the promoted brands.

Therefore, Source Credibility Theory provides an important theoretical foundation for understanding how influencer characteristics influence consumer purchase behavior.

2.4 The Three Parts of Source Credibility

Ohanian (1990) explains that a messenger's credibility is built on three main parts: expertise, trustworthiness, and attractiveness. Today, researchers widely use these three areas to measure how believable both traditional celebrities and modern online personalities are.

- Expertise means how much knowledge and skill an online figure seems to have in a certain area. When these personalities show they know what they are talking about, shoppers view them as dependable. This is because followers believe experts truly understand the products they are showing.
- Trustworthiness is about how honest and reliable the online figure appears to be. If shoppers feel that a personality is genuine, they are much more willing to believe their product recommendations.
- Attractiveness looks at the overall appeal of the personality. This includes their looks, their character, and how likable they are. Appealing figures find it easier to grab a shopper's attention and leave a good impression.

Past research confirms that when online figures score highly in these three areas, they have a much stronger impact on how shoppers feel and what they ultimately decide to buy (Weismueller et al., 2020).

2.5 Expertise

Expertise refers to how much knowledge, skill, and practical experience a messenger appears to have about a specific topic or product. Within the study of credibility, it is a primary reason why people choose to listen to a particular source. When an online personality demonstrates a deep and thorough understanding of what they are talking about, their audience naturally views them as a qualified, capable, and reliable guide.

In the world of online marketing, these personalities usually show their knowledge by providing detailed product reviews, offering practical demonstrations, and comparing different items clearly. If an online figure can easily explain how a

complex product works or highlight its specific benefits, shoppers feel confident that the recommendation is based on actual facts rather than just a paid advertising script. This visible expertise makes the promotional message much stronger and far more convincing to the everyday viewer.

This high level of knowledge is especially valuable when shoppers are thinking about buying items from foreign markets. Because international shopping involves many unknowns, everyday buyers often lack the firsthand information needed to judge a product's true quality or value. In these uncertain situations, they rely heavily on the specialized knowledge of the online figure to fill in those information gaps. Ultimately, when an online personality is seen as a genuine expert in their field, it greatly reduces the shopper's hesitation and builds the necessary confidence to complete a purchase.

Ultimately, when an online personality is seen as a genuine expert in their field, it greatly reduces the shopper's hesitation and builds the necessary confidence to complete a purchase. Previous research has also confirmed that expertise enhances the persuasiveness of marketing messages and increases consumer trust toward the endorsed products (Erdogan, 1999; Casaló et al., 2018).

2.6 Brand Attitude

A brand attitude represents a consumer's overall and comprehensive view of a company. Essentially, it is a summary of how a person perceives a brand, which develops over time. This overall view is influenced by various factors, such as a consumer's past interactions with the company, their personal beliefs in the values upheld by the brand, and their general understanding of its products.

If a consumer consistently hears positive news or has pleasant experiences, their perception of a brand will naturally improve. A positive attitude towards a brand is highly valuable, as it directly influences consumer behaviour.

When people have a positive opinion of a brand, their willingness to purchase its products increases significantly. They move from simply being aware of the brand to actively choosing it over other options.

In the modern world of online advertising, popular online influencers play a crucial role in shaping consumer attitudes. Because shoppers often cannot try a product for themselves — especially when buying online or from abroad — they look to influencers for guidance. When an online influencer shares their personal experiences and

recommends certain products, they provide a clear rationale for their followers to view the brand positively.

This process occurs through a natural transfer of feeling. If a consumer perceives an online influencer as authentic, trustworthy, and attractive, they are more likely to trust their recommendations. These positive feelings and the trust that has been built are often transferred directly to the product being promoted. Consequently, the positive relationship between the consumer and the online influencer helps to foster stronger, more favourable, and longer-lasting attitudes towards the brand itself. Consequently, the positive relationship between the consumer and the online influencer helps to foster stronger, more favourable, and longer-lasting attitudes towards the brand itself. Brand attitude is also influenced by both cognitive and affective responses, which are shaped by marketing communication and external endorsements (Spears & Singh, 2004).

2.7 Purchase Intention

Purchase intention refers to the likelihood that a person will buy a particular product or choose a specific brand in the future. In the field of marketing research, professionals often use this concept as a key tool for predicting consumer behaviour. As it is often difficult to track actual sales before they occur, measuring purchase intention becomes a practical and reliable means of understanding future purchasing habits.

According to Dodds, Monroe and Grivall (1991), the desire to purchase does not arise by chance. On the contrary, it depends largely on how the consumer evaluates and values the product or brand they are considering. When people see a product and form a positive opinion about its quality, price or utility, their actual willingness to spend money on that product may increase.

In short, a positive perception of the brand generally leads directly to a higher likelihood of future purchases. When it comes to online shopping, however, this can be somewhat more complex.

As buyers cannot physically touch or try out the product, their purchasing decisions are heavily influenced by information from external sources. They often read customer reviews, seek personal recommendations, or turn to popular online influencers for endorsement before making their decision. This external information helps bridge the gap created by the lack of a direct purchasing experience, bolstering the confidence consumers need to complete the purchase.

Given the clear link between what people think and what they plan to do, researchers often use purchase intent as a definitive indicator of performance in consumer behaviour research. This represents a clear, measurable objective that helps explain how various factors — such as brand trust, advertising or online influencers — ultimately influence the purchasing decisions consumers make. Given the clear link between what people think and what they plan to do, researchers often use purchase intent as a definitive indicator of performance in consumer behaviour research. Purchase intention is widely considered a strong predictor of actual consumer behavior and is influenced by attitudes, trust, and perceived value (Ajzen, 1991; Zeithaml, 1988).

2.8 Uncertainty Avoidance

The concept of 'uncertainty avoidance' describes the degree to which people are reluctant to face unknown or unclear situations. Hofstede (2001) first introduced this idea as a key component of his research into the behaviour of different cultures. In other words, this concept measures the degree of discomfort a person feels when they cannot predict what will happen next. When people face situations without clear answers or certain outcomes, those who strongly avoid uncertainty naturally seek ways to make everything more predictable and secure.

In the world of shopping, consumers who strongly avoid uncertainty look for clear details and reliable information before deciding to buy something. As they wish to avoid unnecessary risks with their money, they choose to remain loyal to brands they already know and trust. For these shoppers, obtaining guaranteed facts and a proven track record is far more important than taking a chance on something new and untested.

This concept becomes extremely important when analyzing international online shopping. When consumers buy items from foreign markets, they face more uncertainty than usual. They may worry whether the product is genuinely high quality, whether the international shipping process is reliable, or whether the foreign brand is truly authentic. As they cannot visit the shop or see the product in person, the sense of risk becomes much greater than when shopping locally.

Consequently, the buyer's desire to avoid uncertainty plays a key role in their behaviour in the global online marketplace. This directly influences the level of trust they place in the brand before they feel comfortable making a purchase. If the consumer is very risk-averse, they will require a much higher level of trust — which is often built through online influencers — before the desire to buy material. Consequently, the

buyer's desire to avoid uncertainty plays a key role in their behaviour in the global online marketplace. In online environments, consumers with high uncertainty avoidance tend to rely more on trusted sources and risk-reducing strategies when making purchase decisions (Gefen, 2003).

2.9 Previous Research Related to Influencer Credibility and Purchase Intention

Table 2.1 presents a summary of previous studies related to influencer credibility, brand trust, brand attitude, and purchase intention in the context of online and cross-border e-commerce. Previous research has highlighted the importance of influencer marketing in shaping consumer perceptions and purchase behavior.

No	Author (Year)	Dependent Variable	Independent Variable	Research Findings
1	Roobina Ohanian (1990)	Consumer attitude	Expertise, Trustworthiness, Attractiveness	The credibility of celebrity endorsers consists of expertise, trustworthiness, and attractiveness, which significantly influence consumers' perceptions and attitudes.
2	Kristin Freberg et al. (2011)	Consumer behavior	Social media influencers	Social media influencers can affect followers' attitudes and purchasing decisions through their content and interactions on social media platforms.
3	Arjun Chaudhuri & Morris B. Holbrook (2001)	Brand loyalty / Purchase behavior	Brand trust	Brand trust plays a significant role in influencing brand loyalty and consumer purchasing behavior.
4	Kevin Lane Keller (1993)	Consumer response	Brand attitude	Consumers' attitudes toward a brand influence their

				evaluation of the brand and their purchasing decisions.
5	William B. Dodds et al. (1991)	Purchase intention	Product evaluation (price, brand, store information)	Consumers' evaluations of products and brands significantly influence their purchase intention.
6	Weismueller et al. (2020)	Purchase intention	Influencer credibility	Influencer credibility positively affects consumers' purchase intention on social media platforms.
7	Rahim et al. (2023)	Purchase intention	Influencer credibility	Influencer credibility significantly influences millennials' purchase intention in Malaysia.
8	Geert Hofstede (2001)	Consumer decision behavior	Uncertainty avoidance	Consumers with high uncertainty avoidance prefer reliable information sources and trusted brands when making purchasing decisions.
9	Bao et al. (2022)	Purchase intention	Cross-border e-commerce perception	Consumers may experience higher uncertainty when purchasing products from foreign brands, which affects their purchase intention.

2.10 Research Gaps and Study Objectives

While previous research has explored many different elements that drive a shopper to make a purchase online, a few important pieces of the puzzle are still missing. By closely reviewing past studies, it becomes clear that certain specific areas need more attention to fully understand how international online shopping works today.

The first missing piece relates to the specific setting of international trade. Many previous studies have heavily focused on how trusted online personalities affect a

shopper's desire to buy within general social media platforms or standard, local online shopping (Freberg et al., 2011; Weismueller et al., 2020). However, very few studies have specifically examined how these online figures perform in the unique environment of cross-border e-commerce. Buying from a foreign country involves different challenges and worries than buying locally, so it is necessary to understand exactly how an online figure's credibility works in this specific, international situation.

The second gap involves the hidden steps between seeing an online promotion and actually buying the product. Most past research has simply looked at the direct link between an influencer's credibility and a shopper's final decision to buy. While experts have proven that trusting a brand and having a good attitude toward it are vital for business (Chaudhuri & Holbrook, 2001; Keller, 1993), researchers have not paid enough attention to how these two factors act as connecting bridges. There is a need to better understand how an online personality's message first builds brand trust and a positive brand attitude, which then naturally leads to the final purchase.

The third missing area concerns how cultural feelings about risk change shopping habits. (Hofstede 2001) introduced the idea of "uncertainty avoidance," which simply means how uncomfortable people feel when dealing with unknown or unpredictable situations. When shopping from foreign countries, the level of the unknown is naturally higher. Yet, very little research has explored how a shopper's personal dislike of uncertainty affects the relationship between trusting a brand and actually deciding to buy from it. It is important to explore if highly cautious shoppers need an extra level of brand trust before they feel safe spending their money on foreign goods.

Because of these missing pieces, this study sets out to provide clearer answers. The main goal is to figure out exactly how the believability of an online personality affects the willingness of Malaysian shoppers to buy items from Chinese online brands. To give a complete picture, this research will also look closely at the connecting steps—specifically, how brand trust and brand attitude bridge the gap between the online figure and the final purchase. Finally, the study will explore how a shopper's personal desire to avoid uncertainty changes this entire shopping process.

Chapter 3 Theoretical Framework

3.1 Variable Selection and Description

This study bases its framework on the Source Credibility Model (SCM) and earlier research on how online personalities influence what people choose to buy. In simple terms, this model explores how the qualities of the person delivering a message change how an audience receives that message. Based on (Ohanian, 1990), a person's credibility mainly comes down to three areas: how trustworthy they are, how much they know, and how appealing they are.

For this research, the plan uses three main starting points: the influencer's honesty (trustworthiness), their knowledge (expertise), and their overall appeal (attractiveness). The study also looks at two middle steps that connect the influencer to the final choice: how much the buyer trusts the brand and how they feel about the brand overall. Additionally, the study includes a condition that can change the final result, which is how much the buyer dislikes taking risks (uncertainty avoidance). Finally, the end goal we are measuring is how likely a person is to actually buy the product (purchase intention).

3.1.1 Influencer Trustworthiness

Influencer trustworthiness is simply about whether people see a content creator as honest, reliable, and genuine. When an influencer comes across as real and speaks truthfully about a product, audiences are much more likely to believe their message. this basic idea is supported by (Hovland and Weiss, 1951), who noted that people are more easily won over by sources they already trust.

In the online world, influencers build this trust slowly over time by regularly interacting with their followers and sharing honest content (Freberg et al., 2011). This is especially important when people buy products from other countries. In these situations, shoppers naturally worry about whether the item will be high quality and arrive safely (Bao et al., 2022). A trustworthy influencer helps calm these fears. If a consumer believes the influencer is an honest person, they are highly likely to pass that trust on to the brand the influencer is talking about (Weismueller et al., 2020).

3.1.2 Influencer Expertise

Influencer expertise refers to how much skill, knowledge, and hands-on experience an influencer has with a specific type of product. Influencers who clearly know what they are talking about can offer deep explanations and helpful advice. This helps regular buyers understand exactly how a product works and why it might be useful to them.

(Ohanian, 1990) pointed out that having expertise is a major part of being credible and makes a person much more convincing. When people shop across borders, they usually do not know much about foreign brands. Because of this lack of information, they depend heavily on knowledgeable influencers to explain why a product is worth their money. As earlier research shows, an influencer's knowledge helps clear up confusion and makes consumers feel much more confident when they are deciding whether to buy something (Weismueller et al., 2020).

3.1.3 Influencer Attractiveness

When we talk about an influencer's attractiveness, it refers not only to physical appearance but also to personality, likability, and overall appeal. Influencers who are attractive in these ways are more effective at capturing attention and building interpersonal connections with their audience (Erdogan, 1999).

(Ohanian, 1990) identified attractiveness as one of the three key dimensions of source credibility. Beyond merely attracting attention, appealing influencers are able to create stronger emotional bonds with their followers. This emotional connection enhances consumers' perceptions of the endorsed brands and increases the effectiveness of marketing communication (Freberg et al., 2011; Till & Busler, 2000).

Simply put, when consumers find an influencer likable and appealing, they tend to transfer these positive feelings to the products or brands being promoted, resulting in more favorable brand evaluations (Kahle & Homer, 1985).

3.1.4 Brand Trust

Brand trust refers to the consumer's belief that a company is reliable and will fulfill its promises. In online shopping contexts, especially in cross-border e-commerce, trust becomes particularly important because consumers cannot physically inspect products before purchase. This lack of direct experience increases perceived risk and uncertainty (Pavlou, 2003; Gefen et al., 2003).

Past research confirms that trust is a major factor influencing consumer behavior and purchase decisions (Chaudhuri & Holbrook, 2001). In digital environments, trust helps reduce uncertainty and facilitates online transactions (Kim et al., 2008). Influencers act as an important bridge in building this trust by sharing personal experiences and providing product recommendations. When consumers perceive influencers as credible, they are more likely to transfer that trust to the endorsed brand, thereby increasing their willingness to rely on the brand (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017).

3.1.5 Brand Attitude

Brand attitude is simply the overall positive or negative feeling a consumer has toward a brand. This attitude does not develop instantly but is formed gradually through consumers' accumulated experiences, exposure to information, and social influences (Solomon, 2018)

According to Keller (1993), a consumer's attitude toward a brand is a crucial determinant in predicting behavioral responses, particularly purchase intention. In the context of social media marketing, influencers play a significant role in shaping these attitudes. Through product presentations, personal experiences, and online interactions, influencers provide both informational and emotional cues that influence consumers' perceptions of brands. When consumers perceive influencers as credible and relatable, they are more likely to develop favorable attitudes toward the endorsed brand (Lou & Yuan, 2019; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020).

3.1.6 Purchase Intention

Purchase intention is the measure of how likely a person is to actually buy a product in the future. In research, it is commonly used as a strong clue to guess what a consumer's final buying action will be.

As (Dodds et al., 1991) explained, a person's intention to buy is deeply affected by how they judge both the product itself and the brand making it. In the online shopping space, and particularly when dealing with foreign markets, buyers rely heavily on outside clues—like an influencer's stamp of approval. Because they cannot check the product themselves, their trust in the brand and their overall feeling about the brand are the main forces that push them toward the final decision to buy.

3.1.7 Uncertainty Avoidance

Uncertainty avoidance describes how much a person wants to stay away from unpredictable or risky situations. This idea was first brought forward by (Hofstede, 2001).

When buying things from overseas, shoppers face a lot of unknowns. They might worry about whether the product is fake, if it will break easily, or if it will even arrive at their door (Bao et al., 2022). People who really dislike taking risks (those with high uncertainty avoidance) will try to find ways to feel safe. To do this, they lean heavily on information from people they already trust and prefer to buy from brands they recognize (Hofstede, 2001). Because of this fear of the unknown, uncertainty avoidance can change how much a person needs to trust a brand before they are willing to make a purchase.

3.2 Research Framework

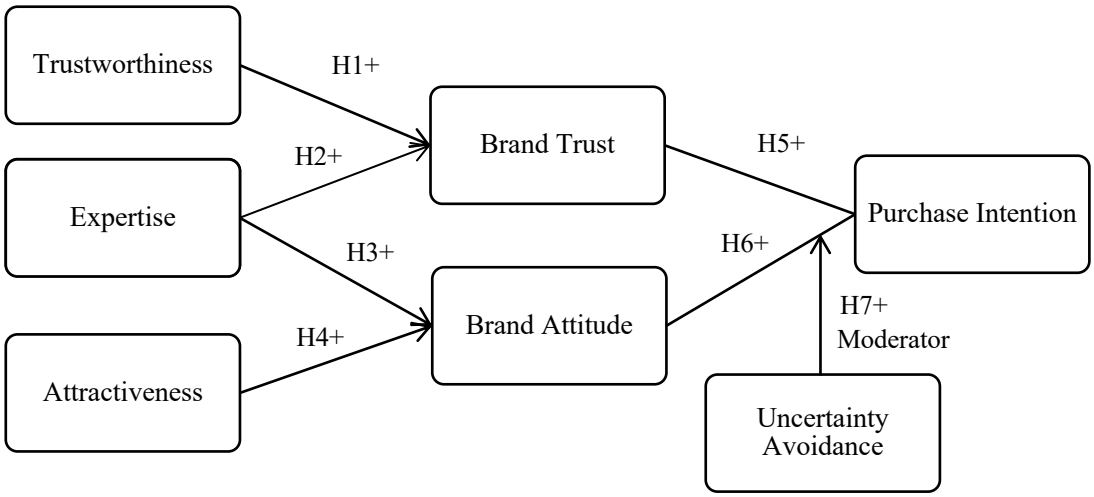

Figure 3.1 Research Framework

3.3 Hypothesis Development

3.3.1 Influencer Trustworthiness and Brand Trust

Influencer trustworthiness refers to the extent to which consumers perceive an influencer as honest, reliable, and sincere. In social media marketing, consumers often rely on influencers' recommendations when evaluating products. When an influencer is perceived as trustworthy, consumers are more likely to believe the information provided and feel more confident about the recommended products. This is supported

by Source Credibility Theory, which suggests that people are more likely to accept information from credible sources (Hovland & Weiss, 1951).

Previous studies have shown that trustworthy influencers can significantly increase consumers' trust toward the brands they promote (Weismueller et al., 2020). In addition, influencer credibility plays an important role in building consumer trust in brands on social media (Lou & Yuan, 2019). This is especially important in cross-border e-commerce contexts where consumers may have limited knowledge about foreign brands (Bao et al., 2022).

Therefore, when Malaysian consumers perceive an influencer as trustworthy, they are more likely to develop trust toward the Chinese cross-border e-commerce brands recommended by the influencer.

H1: Influencer trustworthiness has a positive influence on brand trust.

3.3.2 Influencer Expertise and Brand Trust

Influencer expertise refers to the perceived knowledge, skills, and experience that an influencer has in a specific field. Influencers who are considered experts are often able to provide more detailed product information and professional advice to their followers. According to Ohanian (1990), expertise is one of the key dimensions of source credibility.

When consumers perceive that an influencer has high expertise, they are more likely to believe that the influencer understands the product well and provides accurate information. This perception can increase consumers' confidence in the product and the brand being promoted. In cross-border e-commerce, where consumers may have limited knowledge about foreign products, expertise becomes an important factor that helps reduce uncertainty (Bao et al., 2022).

Furthermore, previous research suggests that influencers with higher expertise are perceived as more reliable, which strengthens consumer trust toward the promoted brand (Ki & Kim, 2019).

Therefore, influencers with higher expertise are more likely to build brand trust among consumers.

H2: Influencer expertise has a positive influence on brand trust.

3.3.3 Influencer Expertise and Brand Attitude

Brand attitude refers to consumers' overall evaluation of a brand. Influencer expertise can play an important role in shaping consumers' perceptions of a brand. When influencers demonstrate professional knowledge about a product, consumers may view the brand as more reliable and valuable.

Expert influencers often provide detailed explanations, tutorials, and product comparisons, which help consumers better understand the product. As a result, consumers may develop more positive feelings toward the brand being promoted. Previous studies also suggest that credible sources can influence consumer attitudes (Freberg et al., 2011). In addition, expert endorsers are more effective in shaping positive brand attitudes (Erdogan, 1999).

Therefore, influencer expertise may contribute to forming a favorable brand attitude.

H3: Influencer expertise has a positive influence on brand attitude.

3.3.4 Influencer Attractiveness and Brand Attitude

Influencer attractiveness refers to the overall appeal of an influencer, including physical appearance, personality, and likability. Attractive influencers are more likely to capture consumers' attention and generate positive emotions. According to Ohanian (1990), attractiveness is one of the main components of source credibility.

When consumers feel attracted to or admire an influencer, they are more likely to develop favorable attitudes toward the products and brands promoted by the influencer. In social media environments, influencers with strong personal appeal often create emotional connections with their followers (Freberg et al., 2011).

In addition, attractive sources are more persuasive because consumers tend to associate positive feelings with them (McGuire, 1985). Therefore, this emotional connection can positively influence consumers' attitudes toward the brand.

H4: Influencer attractiveness has a positive influence on brand attitude.

3.3.5 Brand Trust and Purchase Intention

Brand trust plays an important role in influencing consumers' purchase decisions. When consumers trust a brand, they believe that the brand is reliable and capable of

delivering quality products. This confidence reduces perceived risk and increases consumers' willingness to purchase.

Previous research shows that brand trust significantly influences consumer behavior and purchase decisions (Chaudhuri & Holbrook, 2001). In online environments, trust becomes even more important because consumers cannot directly inspect products (Bao et al., 2022).

In addition, trust is a critical factor in online purchasing environments, especially when uncertainty is high (Gefen et al., 2003). Therefore, when consumers develop strong trust in a brand, they are more likely to have a higher purchase intention.

H5: Brand trust has a positive influence on purchase intention.

3.3.6 Brand Attitude and Purchase Intention

Brand attitude reflects consumers' overall evaluation of a brand. When consumers have a positive attitude toward a brand, they are more likely to consider purchasing products from that brand.

According to Keller (1993), brand attitude plays an important role in shaping consumer responses and purchase behavior. In addition, the Theory of Planned Behavior suggests that positive attitudes can influence behavioral intention (Ajzen, 1991).

In influencer marketing, positive brand attitudes can be formed when consumers perceive influencers as credible or attractive (Freberg et al., 2011). These positive attitudes increase consumers' willingness to purchase the recommended products.

H6: Brand attitude has a positive influence on purchase intention.

3.3.7 Moderating Role of Uncertainty Avoidance

Uncertainty avoidance refers to individuals' tendency to avoid uncertain or risky situations. This concept was introduced by Hofstede (2001). In cross-border e-commerce, consumers often face uncertainties related to product quality, delivery reliability, and brand unfamiliarity (Bao et al., 2022).

Consumers with higher levels of uncertainty avoidance tend to rely more on trust when making purchase decisions. Previous studies suggest that when perceived risk is high, consumers depend more on trusted information sources (Pavlou, 2003).

Therefore, when consumers strongly avoid uncertainty, brand trust may play a more important role in influencing purchase intention.

H7: Uncertainty avoidance positively moderates the relationship between brand trust and purchase intention.

Chapter 4: Research Methods and Data Analysis

This chapter outlines the methods used to conduct the study and review the collected information. Specifically, it explains how the data was gathered, how the survey was created, and how different concepts were measured. It also describes the steps taken to analyze the numbers and test the initial predictions.

To study consumer habits, this research uses a number-based approach. This method is commonly used to see how different factors relate to one another. Information was collected through an online survey and then reviewed using a software program called SmartPLS. A specific statistical tool, known as PLS-SEM, was used to confirm that the survey was reliable and to map out how the different ideas connect to each other.

The rest of this chapter is divided into straightforward sections. These cover the data collection process, the design of the survey, the way factors were measured, and the step-by-step procedures used to analyze the results.

4.1 Data Collection

This study collected data through an online survey administered via the Tencent Questionnaire platform. Online surveys are widely used in consumer research due to their efficiency in reaching a large number of respondents within a short period of time.

The questionnaire was distributed to Malaysian consumers through social media platforms, including WhatsApp, WeChat, and Instagram. Participation in the survey was voluntary, and respondents were informed that the data collected would be used solely for academic purposes.

At the beginning of the questionnaire, a screening question was included to ensure that respondents had prior exposure to social media influencers promoting Chinese cross-border e-commerce brands. Only participants who answered “Yes” were allowed to proceed with the survey.

The data collection process was conducted over approximately one month. During this period, the responses were carefully reviewed to ensure completeness and consistency. A total of 221 responses were collected. After data screening, 20 responses were excluded due to incompleteness or inconsistency, resulting in 201 valid responses for subsequent analysis. The final dataset was analyzed using the SmartPLS software.

4.2 Questionnaire Design

The survey for this study was built using past research on how online personalities affect shopping habits and is split into two main parts to make it clear and easy to answer. The first section asks for basic background information, like age, gender, and social media use. This helps create a clear picture of who is taking the survey and ensures they fit the needs of the study. The second section focuses on the core ideas outlined in Chapter 3. It asks participants to rate the online personality's honesty, knowledge, and appeal, while also measuring the buyer's trust in the brand, their overall feelings about the brand, their desire to buy the product, and their comfort with risk.

All the survey questions were adapted from trusted past studies to make sure the results are accurate and dependable. Participants answered using a five-point rating system, choosing options ranging from "strongly disagree" to "strongly agree." This rating method is popular in consumer research because it lets people share their views clearly and provides numbers that are easy to review.

4.3 Variable Measurement

This study measures all variables based on established scales from previous literature to ensure reliability and validity. All constructs are measured using multiple items adapted from prior studies.

Variable	Code	Measurement Item	Source
Influencer Trustworthiness (IT)	IT1	The influencer is honest.	Ohanian (1990)
	IT2	The influencer is trustworthy.	Ohanian (1990)
	IT3	The influencer is dependable.	Ohanian (1990)
	IT4	The influencer provides reliable information.	Ohanian (1990)
Influencer Expertise (IE)	IE1	The influencer is knowledgeable about the products.	Ohanian (1990)
	IE2	The influencer is experienced in reviewing such products.	Ohanian (1990)

Variable	Code	Measurement Item	Source
	IE3	The influencer is an expert in this product category.	Ohanian (1990)
	IE4	The influencer has sufficient expertise to evaluate the products.	Ohanian (1990)
Influencer Attractiveness (IA)	IA1	The influencer is attractive.	Ohanian (1990); Freberg et al. (2011)
	IA2	The influencer is appealing.	Ohanian (1990); Freberg et al. (2011)
	IA3	The influencer has a pleasant appearance.	Ohanian (1990); Freberg et al. (2011)
	IA4	The influencer is likable.	Ohanian (1990); Freberg et al. (2011)
Brand Trust (BT)	BT1	I trust the brand recommended by the influencer.	Chaudhuri & Holbrook (2001)
	BT2	This brand is reliable.	Chaudhuri & Holbrook (2001)
	BT3	This brand keeps its promises.	Chaudhuri & Holbrook (2001)
	BT4	This brand delivers quality products.	Chaudhuri & Holbrook (2001)
Brand Attitude (BA)	BA1	I have a favorable opinion of this brand.	Keller (1993)
	BA2	I like this brand.	Keller (1993)
	BA3	This brand is appealing to me.	Keller (1993)
	BA4	I have a positive attitude toward this brand.	Keller (1993)

Variable	Code	Measurement Item	Source
Purchase Intention (PI)	PI1	I intend to purchase this brand.	Dodds et al. (1991)
	PI2	I will probably buy products from this brand.	Dodds et al. (1991)

4.4 Data Analysis Method

The data collected in this study were analyzed using the SmartPLS software, which is widely applied in social science and marketing research. Specifically, Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) was employed to examine the relationships among the constructs in the research model. PLS-SEM is particularly suitable for complex models involving multiple constructs and indicators, and it is effective when the sample size is relatively small and data distribution does not strictly meet normality assumptions (Hair et al., 2019).

The data analysis procedure consists of two main stages: the assessment of the measurement model and the evaluation of the structural model. In the first stage, the measurement model is examined to ensure the reliability and validity of the constructs. This includes assessing indicator reliability, internal consistency reliability (Cronbach's alpha and composite reliability), and convergent validity using Average Variance Extracted (AVE). In addition, discriminant validity is evaluated to confirm that each construct is distinct from others in the model (Hair et al., 2019).

In the second stage, the structural model is assessed to test the hypothesized relationships among constructs. This involves analyzing path coefficients, t-values, and p-values to determine the significance and strength of relationships. The coefficient of determination (R^2) is also examined to evaluate the explanatory power of the model. Furthermore, a bootstrapping procedure is conducted to assess the statistical significance of the path coefficients and ensure the robustness of the results (Hair et al., 2019).

Finally, this study also examines the moderating effect of uncertainty avoidance on the relationship between brand trust and purchase intention. This is achieved by incorporating an interaction term into the structural model to determine whether the strength of the relationship varies under different levels of uncertainty avoidance.

Chapter 5 Data Analysis

5.1 Data Scale

As part of this research, a structured questionnaire was used to collect quantitative data from the participants. The questionnaire was distributed online over a one-month period, from 19 February 2026 to 18 March 2026. A total of 221 responses were received. After data verification, 20 responses were excluded due to incompleteness or inconsistency, resulting in 201 valid responses for further analysis.

The questionnaire consisted of two main sections: demographic information and measurement of the study constructs. The constructs in this study included influencer credibility, brand trust, and purchase intention. All measurement items were adapted from established literature to ensure content validity and reliability (Ohanian, 1990; Chaudhuri & Holbrook, 2001; Dodds et al., 1991).

A five-point Likert scale was used to measure all items, ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). The Likert scale is widely used in social science research as it effectively captures respondents' attitudes and perceptions in a structured manner (Likert, 1932; Joshi et al., 2015). This approach allows for easy quantification of subjective responses and is considered appropriate for behavioral research.

5.2 Descriptive Statistical Analysis

5.2.1 Sample Statistical Characteristics

This section presents the demographic characteristics of the respondents, including gender, age, education level, income level, and online shopping frequency.

Table 5.1 Respondent Characteristics

Variable	Sample Characteristics	Frequency	Percentages (%)
Gender	Male	81	40.3
	Female	110	54.7
	Prefer not to say	10	5
Age	18-24	138	68.7
	25-34	56	27.9

	35-44	3	1.5
	45 above	4	2.0
Education	Diploma	27	13.4
	Bachelor degree	132	65.7
	Master Degree	23	11.4
	Other	19	9.5
	Total	201	100
Income	Below Rm2000	81	40.3
	RM2000-RM4000	74	36.8
	RM4000-RM6000	23	11.4
	RM6000 above	23	11.4
Frequency of online shopping	Rarely	13	6.5
	Sometimes	84	41.8
	Often	81	40.3
	Very Often	23	11.4

According to Table 5.1, the majority of survey participants are female (54.7%), followed by males (40.3%), whilst 5% chose not to disclose their gender.

With regard to age, the majority of participants are aged between 18 and 24 (68.7%), followed by those aged between 25 and 34 (27.9%), indicating that the sample consists mainly of young people.

With regard to educational attainment, the majority of survey participants hold a bachelor's degree (65.7%), followed by those with a higher technical diploma (13.4%) and a master's degree (11.4%), whilst a smaller percentage fall into the 'Other' category (9.5%).

With regard to income level, the majority of respondents indicated that their income is less than 2,000 Malaysian ringgit (40.3%) or lies between 2,000 and 4,000 Malaysian ringgit (36.8%). A smaller percentage had an income between 4,000 and 6,000 Malaysian ringgit (11.4%) and over 6,000 Malaysian ringgit (11.4%).

Finally, regarding the frequency of online shopping, a larger number of participants stated that they shop occasionally (41.8%) or frequently (40.3%), indicating that the average participant is accustomed to shopping online.

5.2.2 Descriptive Analysis of Each Variable

This section presents the descriptive statistics of the main variables in this study, including influencer trustworthiness, influencer expertise, influencer attractiveness, brand trust, brand attitude, purchase intention, and uncertainty avoidance. The results are summarized in Table 5.2.

Table 5.2 Descriptive Statistical Analysis of Each Variable

Variable	N	Mean	Std. Deviation
Influencer Trustworthiness	201	3.39	0.93
Influencer Expertise	201	3.42	0.89
Influencer Attractiveness	201	3.73	0.89
Brand Trust	201	3.66	0.84
Brand Attitude	201	3.76	0.87
Purchase Intention	201	3.72	0.81
Uncertainty Avoidance	201	3.72	0.81

As shown in Table 5.2, the mean values of all variables range from 3.39 to 3.76, indicating a generally moderate to high level of agreement among respondents.

Among these variables, brand attitude had the highest average score (M = 3.76, SD = 0.87), followed by influencer attractiveness (M = 3.73, SD = 0.89),

intent to purchase (M = 3.72, SD = 0.81) and uncertainty avoidance (M = 3.72, SD = 0.81).

This indicates that the respondents, in general, have a relatively positive attitude towards the brand and are easily influenced by the influencer's appeal.

Trust in the brand also had a relatively high average score (M = 3.66, SD = 0.84), which indicates that respondents, in general, showed a moderate level of trust in the brands promoted by influencers.

At the same time, the indicators of influencer trust (M = 3.39, SD = 0.93) and influencer competence (M = 3.42, SD = 0.89) proved to be lower, which shows that the respondents were more neutral in their perceptions of these attributes.

Regarding the standard deviations, all variables ranged between 0.81 and 0.93, indicating a relatively low level of dispersion and suggesting that the respondents' answers were quite consistent.

Overall, the results indicate that the majority of respondents have a positive perception of the variables under study, a finding that is reinforced by the in-depth analysis in the subsequent sections.

5.3 Inferential Statistical Analysis

Inferential statistical analysis was conducted to evaluate the measurement model and ensure the validity and reliability of the constructs. In this study, Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) was applied using SmartPLS software. The assessment of the measurement model includes convergent validity, discriminant validity, and reliability. The results are presented in the following sections.

5.3.1 Convergent Validity Test

Convergent validity refers to the extent to which various indicators of the same construct converge or account for a high proportion of the total variance. It is an important criterion in the evaluation of a measurement model, as it ensures that the construct's indicators effectively measure the same underlying concept.

In this study, convergent validity was assessed by analysing the external loadings of the indicators and the values of the average variance extracted (AVE) for each construct. According to Hair et al. (2019), external loadings should be greater than 0.70 to demonstrate sufficient reliability of the indicator, whilst AVE values should exceed 0.50 to confirm that the construct explains more than half of the variance of its indicators.

Table 5.3 Outer Loading Value

Construct	Item	Outer Loading	Evaluation
Influencer Trustworthiness	IT1	0.905	Valid
	IT2	0.920	Valid
	IT3	0.921	Valid
	IT4	0.895	Valid
Influencer Expertise	IE1	0.845	Valid
	IE2	0.837	Valid
	IE3	0.847	Valid
	IE4	0.863	Valid
Influencer Attractiveness	IA1	0.895	Valid
	IA2	0.921	Valid

	IA3	0.881	Valid
	IA4	0.870	Valid
Brand Trust	BT1	0.853	Valid
	BT2	0.907	Valid
	BT3	0.901	Valid
	BT4	0.894	Valid
Brand Attitude	BA1	0.914	Valid
	BA2	0.936	Valid
	BA3	0.901	Valid
	BA4	0.921	Valid
Purchase Intention	PI1	0.852	Valid
	PI2	0.895	Valid
	PI3	0.896	Valid
	PI4	0.875	Valid
Uncertainty Avoidance	UA1	0.735	Valid
	UA2	0.772	Valid
	UA3	0.814	Valid
	UA4	0.843	Valid

As shown in Table 5.3, all external loads are between 0.735 and 0.936, higher than the recommended threshold of 0.70. This indicates that each measurement item has a strong relationship with its respective construct.

The high external loads indicate that these indicators are reliable and make a significant contribution to the measurement of the construct.

Specifically, the indicators related to influencer credibility showed very high loadings, between 0.895 and 0.921, which indicates a high level of consistency among these items.

Similarly, influencer expertise and attractiveness also showed high coefficients, ranging from 0.837 to 0.863 and from 0.870 to 0.921, respectively. Constructs such as brand trust, brand attitude, and purchase intention also demonstrated high indicator reliability, with all values, in most cases, exceeding 0.85. Although the indicators related to aversion to uncertainty showed slightly lower values, between 0.735 and 0.843, they still met the minimum acceptable threshold, indicating adequate reliability.

Table 5.4 AVE Value

Construct	Average Variance Extracted (AVE)	Evaluation
Influencer Trustworthiness	0.842	Valid
Influencer Expertise	0.791	Valid
Influencer Attractiveness	0.795	Valid
Brand Trust	0.719	Valid
Brand Attitude	0.829	Valid
Purchase Intention	0.774	Valid
Uncertainty Avoidance	0.627	Valid

Furthermore, the AVE values shown in Table 5.4 range from 0.627 to 0.842, and all exceed the recommended threshold of 0.50. This indicates that each construct is capable of explaining more than 50% of the variance in its indicators, thereby ensuring adequate convergent validity.

Among these constructs, the highest AVE value was recorded for trust in the influencer (0.842), followed by brand attitude (0.829) and influencer attractiveness (0.795), indicating that these constructs possess very high explanatory power. Although uncertainty avoidance had the lowest AVE value (0.627), it still exceeded the acceptable threshold, indicating that this construct remains valid within the model.

Overall, the results show that all measurement items and constructs meet the required criteria for convergent validity. Consequently, none of the indicators were excluded, and the measurement model is considered to possess adequate convergent validity.

5.3.2 Discriminant Validity Test

Discriminant validity refers to the extent to which a construct is truly distinct from other constructs in the model. It ensures that a construct captures unique phenomena that are not represented by other constructs. Establishing discriminant validity is essential in order to confirm that there is no significant overlap between different constructs and that each construct measures a separate concept.

In this study, discriminant validity was assessed using two widely accepted approaches, namely the cross-loading criterion and the Fornell-Larcker criterion. These

methods are commonly recommended in PLS-SEM analysis to ensure the robustness of the measurement model (Hair et al., 2019).

First, the cross-loading criterion was examined, and the results are presented in **Table 5.5**.

Table 5.5 Cross Loading Result

	Brand Attitude	**Brand Trust**	**Influencer Attractiveness**	**Influencer Expertise**	**Influencer Trustworthiness**	**Purchase Intention**	**Uncertainty Avoidance**
BA1	**0.914**	0.780	0.418	0.591	0.619	0.727	0.429
BA2	**0.936**	0.811	0.397	0.558	0.576	0.750	0.473
BA3	**0.901**	0.736	0.388	0.517	0.588	0.718	0.426
BA4	**0.921**	0.804	0.415	0.561	0.608	0.744	0.483
BT1	0.719	**0.853**	0.336	0.563	0.621	0.698	0.397
BT2	0.791	**0.907**	0.362	0.558	0.609	0.663	0.434
BT3	0.744	**0.901**	0.337	0.531	0.554	0.705	0.441
BT4	0.780	**0.894**	0.384	0.541	0.564	0.669	0.422
IA1	0.431	0.391	**0.895**	0.530	0.457	0.407	0.255
IA2	0.358	0.327	**0.921**	0.563	0.464	0.379	0.159
IA3	0.323	0.303	**0.881**	0.437	0.370	0.338	0.276
IA4	0.434	0.383	**0.870**	0.538	0.521	0.368	0.247
IE1	0.531	0.519	0.546	**0.845**	0.628	0.480	0.246
IE2	0.507	0.532	0.572	**0.837**	0.644	0.441	0.326
IE3	0.483	0.476	0.391	**0.847**	0.648	0.460	0.177
IE4	0.535	0.562	0.465	**0.863**	0.698	0.529	0.239
IT1	0.582	0.594	0.474	0.683	**0.905**	0.539	0.201
IT2	0.575	0.580	0.468	0.694	**0.920**	0.544	0.242
IT3	0.563	0.596	0.472	0.696	**0.921**	0.479	0.219
IT4	0.647	0.634	0.462	0.737	**0.895**	0.554	0.303
PI1	0.764	0.724	0.417	0.574	0.584	**0.852**	0.429
PI2	0.635	0.641	0.367	0.450	0.481	**0.895**	0.403
PI3	0.689	0.661	0.350	0.479	0.480	**0.896**	0.402
PI4	0.717	0.672	0.342	0.470	0.491	**0.875**	0.397

UA1	0.469	0.454	0.301	0.388	0.357	0.407	**0.735**
UA2	0.317	0.326	0.167	0.200	0.202	0.271	**0.772**
UA3	0.340	0.322	0.124	0.115	0.121	0.312	**0.814**
UA4	0.400	0.378	0.210	0.188	0.144	0.433	**0.843**

As shown in Table 5.5, all indicators exhibit higher loadings on their respective constructs compared to other constructs. This indicates that each measurement item is more strongly associated with its intended construct than with any other constructs in the model.

For instance, the items measuring brand attitude (BA1–BA4) show the highest loadings on the brand attitude construct, ranging from 0.901 to 0.936, compared to lower loadings on other constructs. Similarly, the items for brand trust (BT1–BT4), influencer attractiveness (IA1–IA4), influencer expertise (IE1–IE4), influencer trustworthiness (IT1–IT4), purchase intention (PI1–PI4), and uncertainty avoidance (UA1–UA4) all demonstrate the same pattern, where each item loads highest on its corresponding construct.

This clear pattern of higher loadings on the intended constructs indicates that the indicators are well differentiated and do not exhibit cross-loading issues. Therefore, the cross-loading criterion supports the establishment of discriminant validity.

In addition to cross-loadings, the Fornell-Larcker criterion was also applied to further validate discriminant validity. The results are shown in **Table 5.6**.

Table 5.6 Fornell-Larcker Criterion Results

	Brand Attitude	**Brand Trust**	**Influencer Attractiveness**	**Influencer Expertise**	**Influencer Trustworthiness**	**Purchase Intention**	**Uncertainty Avoidance**
BA	0.918						
BT	0.853	0.889					
IA	0.441	0.399	0.892				
IE	0.607	0.617	0.584	0.848			
IT	0.651	0.661	0.515	0.772	0.910		
PI	0.801	0.770	0.421	0.564	0.582	0.880	
UA	0.493	0.476	0.264	0.293	0.266	0.465	0.792

According to the Fornell-Larcker criterion, the square root of the Average Variance Extracted (AVE) for each construct should be greater than its correlations with other constructs. This requirement ensures that a construct shares more variance with its own indicators than with other constructs.

As presented in Table 5.6, the diagonal values, which represent the square root of AVE, are higher than the corresponding inter-construct correlations for all constructs. For example, brand attitude (0.918), brand trust (0.889), influencer attractiveness (0.892), influencer expertise (0.848), influencer trustworthiness (0.910), purchase intention (0.880), and uncertainty avoidance (0.792) all exceed their correlations with other constructs.

These findings indicate that each construct demonstrates sufficient discriminant validity, as the constructs are empirically distinct from one another and there is no significant overlap between them.

Overall, based on both the cross-loading and Fornell-Larcker criteria, discriminant validity is successfully established for all constructs in this study. This confirms that the measurement model is appropriate and can be used for further structural model analysis.

5.3.3 Reliability Test

Reliability refers to the extent to which a measurement instrument produces consistent and stable results. It indicates the internal consistency of the constructs and ensures that the measurement items reliably represent the intended variables.

In this study, reliability was assessed using Cronbach’s alpha and Composite Reliability (CR). According to Hair et al. (2019), the acceptable threshold for both Cronbach’s alpha and Composite Reliability is 0.70 or above, indicating satisfactory internal consistency.

The results of the reliability analysis are presented in Table 5.7.

Table 5.7

	Composite reliability	**Cronbach's alpha**	**Evaluation**
Brand Attitude	0.955	0.938	Reliable
Brand Trust	0.938	0.911	Reliable
Influencer Attrativeness	0.939	0.915	Reliable

Influencer Expertise	0.911	0.870	Reliable
Influencer Trustworthiness	0.951	0.931	Reliable
Purchase Intention	0.932	0.903	Reliable
Uncertainty Avoidance	0.870	0.804	Reliable

As shown in Table 5.7, all constructs demonstrate high levels of reliability. The Composite Reliability values range from 0.819 to 0.938, while Cronbach's alpha values range from 0.804 to 0.938. All values exceed the recommended threshold of 0.70, indicating strong internal consistency among the measurement items.

Specifically, brand attitude shows the highest reliability (CR = 0.938, α = 0.938), followed by influencer trustworthiness (CR = 0.932, α = 0.931) and influencer attractiveness (CR = 0.925, α = 0.915). Other constructs such as brand trust (CR = 0.911, α = 0.911), purchase intention (CR = 0.904, α = 0.903), and influencer expertise (CR = 0.872, α = 0.870) also demonstrate strong reliability.

Although uncertainty avoidance has comparatively lower values (CR = 0.819, α = 0.804), these values still exceed the acceptable threshold, indicating that the construct is reliable.

Overall, the results confirm that all constructs exhibit satisfactory reliability, and the measurement model demonstrates strong internal consistency. Therefore, the constructs are suitable for further analysis in the structural model.

5.4 Inferential Statistical Analysis（Structural Model）

After establishing the reliability and validity of the measurement model, the structural model was assessed to examine the relationships between constructs. The evaluation of the structural model includes collinearity assessment, coefficient of determination (R^2), effect size (f^2), predictive relevance (Q^2), and hypothesis testing.

5.4.1 Collinearity Assessment

Collinearity assessment is conducted to ensure that there is no multicollinearity issue among the predictor constructs in the model. High collinearity may distort the results of the structural model and affect the accuracy of the estimated path coefficients.

In this study, collinearity was evaluated using the Variance Inflation Factor (VIF). According to Hair et al. (2019), VIF values should be below 5.0 to indicate that collinearity is not a critical issue.

The results of the collinearity assessment are presented in Table 5.8.

Table 5.8 Variance Inflation Factor（VIF）Result

Construct	Item	VIF
Brand Attitude	BA1	3.566
	BA2	4.492
	BA3	3.226
	BA4	3.761
Brand Trust	BT1	2.208
	BT2	3.228
	BT3	3.193
	BT4	3.121
Influencer Attractiveness	IA1	3.727
	IA2	5.425
	IA3	3.701
	IA4	2.519
Influencer Expertise	IE1	2.124
	IE2	2.060
	IE3	2.358
	IE4	2.403
Influencer Trustworthiness	IT1	3.238
	IT2	3.996
	IT3	3.941
	IT4	2.845
Purchase Intention	PI1	2.157
	PI2	3.067
	PI3	3.174
	PI4	2.638
Uncertainty Avoidance	UA1	1.342
	UA2	1.710
	UA3	1.965

	UA4	2.025

As shown in Table 5.8, all VIF values range from 1.342 to 5.425. Most of the values are below the recommended threshold of 5.0, indicating that multicollinearity is generally not a concern in this study.

However, one indicator (IA2) slightly exceeds the threshold with a VIF value of 5.425. Despite this, the value is only marginally above the recommended limit and does not indicate a severe collinearity issue. According to previous studies, VIF values slightly above 5 can still be acceptable if they do not significantly affect the overall model.

Overall, the results suggest that collinearity is not a serious issue in this study, and the structural model can be reliably interpreted.

5.4.2 Coefficient of Determination (R^2)

The coefficient of determination (R^2) is used to evaluate the explanatory power of the structural model. It indicates the proportion of variance in the endogenous constructs that can be explained by the exogenous constructs in the model.

According to Hair et al. (2019), R^2 values of 0.75, 0.50, and 0.25 can be described as substantial, moderate, and weak, respectively.

The R^2 values obtained in this study are presented in Table 5.9.

Table 5.9 R-Square Value Result

	R-square	**R-square adjusted**
Brand Attitude	0.380	0.373
Brand Trust	0.465	0.460
Purchase Intention	0.673	0.666

As shown in Table 5.9, the R^2 value for purchase intention is 0.673, indicating a moderate to substantial level of explanatory power. This suggests that the independent variables in the model explain approximately 67.3% of the variance in purchase intention, demonstrating strong predictive capability.

Similarly, brand trust has an R^2 value of 0.465, indicating a moderate level of explanatory power. This implies that the predictors in the model are able to explain 46.5% of the variance in brand trust.

In contrast, brand attitude has an R^2 value of 0.380, which is considered a moderate level of explanatory power. This indicates that 38.0% of the variance in brand attitude is explained by the model.

Overall, the R^2 values suggest that the structural model has acceptable to strong explanatory power, particularly for purchase intention, which shows the highest level of variance explained among the constructs.

5.4.3 Effect Size (f^2)

Effect size (f^2) is used to assess the impact of each exogenous construct on the endogenous constructs in the structural model. It evaluates how much an independent variable contributes to the R^2 value of a dependent variable when it is included or excluded from the model.

According to Hair et al. (2019), f^2 values of 0.02, 0.15, and 0.35 indicate small, medium, and large effect sizes, respectively. The results of the effect size analysis are presented in Table 5.10.

Table 5.10 f-square Value Result

	Brand Attitude	Brand Trust	Influencer Attractiveness	Influencer Expertise	Influencer Trustworthiness	Purchase Intention	Uncertainty Avoidance	Uncertainty Avoidance x Brand Trust
BA						0.206		
BT						0.076		
IA	0.018							
IE	0.299	0.053						
IT		0.158						
PI								
UA						0.011		
UA x BT						0.000		

The results indicate that influencer expertise has a large effect on brand attitude ($f^2 = 0.299$), suggesting that influencer expertise plays a crucial role in shaping consumers' attitudes toward the brand.

In contrast, influencer attractiveness shows a very small effect on brand attitude ($f^2 = 0.018$), indicating that its influence is negligible. Similarly, influencer expertise has a small effect on brand trust ($f^2 = 0.053$), while influencer trustworthiness demonstrates a medium effect on brand trust ($f^2 = 0.158$).

Furthermore, brand attitude has a medium effect on purchase intention ($f^2 = 0.206$), whereas brand trust shows a small effect on purchase intention ($f^2 = 0.076$). This suggests that brand attitude is a stronger predictor of purchase intention compared to brand trust. Overall, the effect size results indicate that influencer expertise and brand attitude exhibit relatively stronger effects in the model, while influencer attractiveness and uncertainty avoidance show minimal or negligible effects.

In addition, uncertainty avoidance has a negligible effect on purchase intention ($f^2 = 0.011$), and its moderating effect (uncertainty avoidance × brand trust) is also negligible ($f^2 = 0.000$), indicating that uncertainty avoidance does not play a significant role in influencing purchase intention in this study.

5.4.4 Predictive Relevance (Q^2)

Predictive relevance (Q^2) is used to assess the predictive accuracy of the structural model. It evaluates how well the model can predict the data points of endogenous constructs. In PLS-SEM, the Q^2 value is obtained through the blindfolding procedure.

According to Hair et al. (2019), a Q^2 value greater than 0 indicates that the model has predictive relevance for a given construct. Furthermore, values of 0.02, 0.15, and 0.35 indicate small, medium, and large predictive relevance, respectively.

The results of the predictive relevance analysis are presented in Table 5.11.

Table 5.11 Q-Square Value Result

	Q^2predict
Brand Attitude	0.350
Brand Trust	0.444
Purchase Intention	0.365

As shown in Table 5.11, all Q^2 values are greater than zero, indicating that the model has sufficient predictive relevance.

Specifically, brand trust recorded the highest Q^2 value (0.444), followed by purchase intention (0.365) and brand attitude (0.350). All of these values exceed the threshold of 0.35, indicating a large level of predictive relevance.

This suggests that the model has strong predictive capability in explaining the endogenous constructs, particularly in predicting brand trust and purchase intention.

Overall, the results confirm that the structural model demonstrates high predictive relevance and is capable of accurately predicting the outcomes of the study.

5.5 Hypothesis Testing

Hypothesis testing is conducted to examine the relationships between constructs in the structural model. In this study, the significance of the hypothesized relationships is assessed using path coefficients, t-values, and p-values obtained through the bootstrapping procedure in SmartPLS.

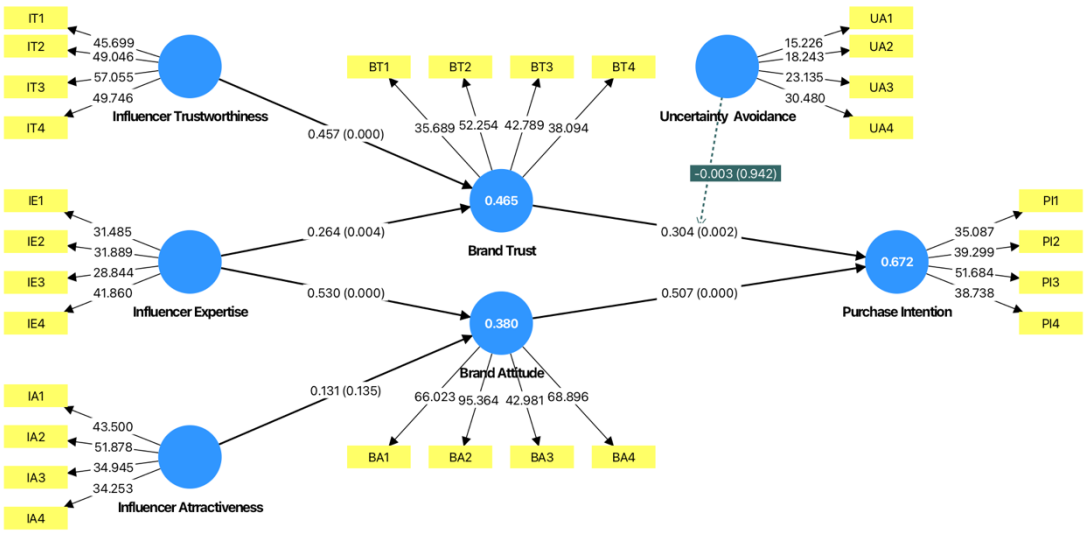

Figure 4.1 Structural Model Analysis

Figure 4.1 presents the structural model results, including the path coefficients and their significance levels obtained from the bootstrapping procedure. The figure

illustrates the relationships among the constructs in the model, along with the corresponding R^2 values for the endogenous variables.

The path coefficients indicate the strength and direction of the relationships between constructs, while the t-values and p-values are used to determine the statistical significance of each hypothesized relationship.

5.5.1 Path Coefficients Test

The path coefficients were evaluated to determine the strength and significance of the relationships between constructs. The results of the hypothesis testing are presented in Table 5.12.

Table 5.12 Hypothesis Testing: Path Coefficient Analysis

Hypothesis		**Path Coefficient**	**STERR**	**T statistic**	**P value**	**Result**
H1	Influencer Trustworthiness → Brand Trust	0.457	0.084	5.437	0.000	Supported
H2	Influencer Expertise → Brand Trust	0.264	0.091	2.910	0.004	Supported
H3	Influencer Expertise → Brand Attitude	0.530	0.066	8.017	0.000	Supported
H4	Influencer Attractiveness → Brand Attitude	0.131	0.088	1.494	0.135	Not Supported
H5	Brand Trust → Purchase Intention	0.304	0.096	3.174	0.002	Supported
H6	Brand Attitude → Purchase Intention	0.507	0.092	5.541	0.000	Supported
H7	Uncertainty Avoidance →	0.070	0.057	1.222	0.222	Not Supported

	Purchase Intention					
H	Uncertainty Avoidance x Brand Trust → Purchase Intention	-0.003	0.042	0.073	0.942	Not Supported

According to Hair et al. (2019), a hypothesis is considered statistically significant when the t-value exceeds 1.96 and the p-value is less than 0.05.

The results indicate that influencer trustworthiness has a significant positive effect on brand trust ($\beta = 0.457$, $t = 5.437$, $p < 0.001$), thus supporting H1. Similarly, influencer expertise significantly influences brand trust ($\beta = 0.264$, $t = 2.910$, $p = 0.004$), supporting H2.

In addition, influencer expertise has a strong and significant positive effect on brand attitude ($\beta = 0.530$, $t = 8.017$, $p < 0.001$), supporting H3. However, influencer attractiveness does not have a significant effect on brand attitude ($\beta = 0.131$, $t = 1.494$, $p = 0.135$), leading to the rejection of H4.

Furthermore, brand trust has a significant positive effect on purchase intention ($\beta = 0.304$, $t = 3.174$, $p = 0.002$), supporting H5. Likewise, brand attitude significantly influences purchase intention ($\beta = 0.507$, $t = 5.541$, $p < 0.001$), supporting H6.

On the other hand, uncertainty avoidance does not have a significant effect on purchase intention ($\beta = 0.070$, $t = 1.222$, $p = 0.222$), resulting in the rejection of H7. Additionally, the moderating effect of uncertainty avoidance on the relationship between brand trust and purchase intention is not significant ($\beta = -0.003$, $t = 0.073$, $p = 0.942$), thus H8 is not supported.

5.6 Summary of Data Analysis

This chapter presents the results of the data analysis, including descriptive statistics, an evaluation of the measurement model, an evaluation of the structural model, and hypothesis testing.

Firstly, a descriptive statistical analysis was conducted to summarise the demographic characteristics of the respondents and the main study variables. The

results showed that, overall, the respondents were familiar with the characteristics of online shopping.

Secondly, the measurement model was evaluated using tests of convergent validity, discriminant validity and reliability. The results confirmed that all constructs met the recommended thresholds for external loadings, average variance extracted (AVE), composite reliability (CR) and Cronbach's alpha, indicating the validity and reliability of the measurement model.

Thirdly, the structural model was evaluated using multicollinearity, the coefficient of determination (R^2), effect size (f^2) and predictive validity (Q^2). The results did not reveal any serious multicollinearity issues. The R^2 values indicated moderate to strong explanatory power, particularly regarding purchase intention. The f^2 results showed that the effects of the independent variables varied across different relationships, whilst the Q^2 values confirmed that the model possessed strong predictive validity.

Finally, hypothesis testing was conducted using path analysis. The results showed that most of the hypothesised relationships were confirmed. It was found that the influencer's expertise and credibility significantly influences brand trust, whilst the influencer's expertise also had a strong influence on brand attitude. Furthermore, both brand trust and brand attitude significantly influenced purchase intention. However, it was found that influencer attractiveness and uncertainty avoidance did not have a significant influence.

Overall, the results provide empirical support for the proposed research model and offer important insights into the factors influencing consumers' purchase intention towards Chinese brands engaged in cross-border e-commerce. The implications of these findings will be discussed in more detail in the following chapter.

Table 5.13 Data Analysis Results

Research Hypothesis	Research Result
H1: Influencer trustworthiness has a positive influence on brand trust toward Chinese cross-border e-commerce brands.	Supported
H2: Influencer expertise has a positive influence on brand trust toward Chinese cross-border e-commerce brands.	Supported
H3: Influencer expertise has a positive influence on brand attitude toward Chinese cross-border e-commerce brands.	Supported

H4: Influencer attractiveness has a positive influence on brand attitude toward Chinese cross-border e-commerce brands.	Not Supported
H5: Brand trust toward Chinese cross-border e-commerce brands has a positive influence on purchase intention.	Supported
H6: Brand attitude toward Chinese cross-border e-commerce brands has a positive influence on purchase intention.	Supported
H7: Uncertainty avoidance positively moderates the relationship between brand trust toward Chinese cross-border e-commerce brands and purchase intention.	Not Supported

Chapter 6 Discussion and Conclusion

6.1 Research Findings

This section discusses the key findings of the study based on the empirical results and research hypotheses.

6.1.1 Influence of Influencer Characteristics on Brand Trust

The findings of this study indicate that influencer trustworthiness ($\beta = 0.457$, $p < 0.001$) and influencer expertise ($\beta = 0.264$, $p = 0.004$) have significant positive effects on brand trust. Among these, influencer trustworthiness demonstrates a stronger impact. This result suggests that consumers are more likely to develop trust in a brand when the influencer promoting the brand is perceived as honest, reliable, and credible. This finding is consistent with the source credibility model proposed by Ohanian, which emphasizes trustworthiness as a key determinant of persuasion effectiveness. Furthermore, the significant role of influencer expertise supports prior studies such as Cheah et al. (2020), which highlight that knowledgeable influencers are more persuasive in shaping consumer perceptions and building trust toward brands. Therefore, the findings confirm that both expertise and trustworthiness are essential components of influencer credibility in enhancing brand trust. This finding is also consistent with prior studies, which suggest that influencer credibility significantly enhances consumer trust and brand perception (De Veirman et al., 2017; Matilde Milanesi, 2018).

6.1.2 Influence of Influencer Characteristics on Brand Attitude

The results reveal that influencer expertise has a significant positive effect on brand attitude ($\beta = 0.530$, $p < 0.001$), indicating a strong influence. In contrast, influencer attractiveness does not have a significant effect on brand attitude ($\beta = 0.131$, $p = 0.135$). The strong impact of expertise suggests that consumers are more influenced by the informational value and knowledge provided by influencers rather than their physical appearance. This finding aligns with previous research, such as Thomas et al. (2022), which emphasizes that expertise enhances the credibility and persuasiveness of marketing messages.

On the other hand, the insignificant effect of attractiveness contradicts traditional assumptions that physical appeal plays a major role in influencing consumer attitudes.

This may be explained by the increasing sophistication of consumers, who prioritize authenticity and informative content over superficial characteristics.

6.1.3 Influence of Brand Factors on Purchase Intention

The findings indicate that both brand attitude ($\beta = 0.506$, $p < 0.001$) and brand trust ($\beta = 0.304$, $p = 0.001$) have significant positive effects on purchase intention, with brand attitude showing a stronger influence. This suggests that consumers' overall evaluation of a brand plays a critical role in shaping their purchase decisions. A positive brand attitude enhances emotional attachment and favorability toward the brand, thereby increasing purchase intention. These findings are consistent with previous studies, such as Tang, which highlight that both cognitive (trust) and affective (attitude) components are important predictors of consumer purchase behavior.

6.1.4 Influence of Uncertainty Avoidance

The results show that uncertainty avoidance does not have a significant effect on purchase intention ($\beta = 0.070$, $p = 0.229$), and its moderating effect on the relationship between brand trust and purchase intention is also not significant ($\beta = -0.011$, $p = 0.812$). This finding suggests that uncertainty avoidance does not play a major role in influencing consumer behavior in this study context. One possible explanation is that consumers have become more familiar with online shopping and cross-border e-commerce platforms, which reduces perceived risk and uncertainty. This result partially contradicts prior research, such as Hofstede, which suggests that uncertainty avoidance significantly influences consumer decision-making. However, the current findings indicate that cultural factors may have a diminishing impact in highly digitalized and globalized environments.

6.1.5 Overall Summary of Findings

Overall, the findings of this study confirm that influencer credibility, particularly expertise and trustworthiness, plays a crucial role in shaping brand trust and brand attitude. These, in turn, significantly influence consumer purchase intention. In contrast, influencer attractiveness and uncertainty avoidance were found to have no significant effects, suggesting that consumers place greater emphasis on credibility, information quality, and brand perception rather than superficial attributes or cultural dimensions.

These findings provide strong empirical support for the proposed research model and contribute to a deeper understanding of consumer behavior in the context of influencer marketing and cross-border e-commerce.

6.2 Research Recommendations（Improved Structure）

Based on the findings of this study, several recommendations are proposed for different stakeholders, including businesses, influencers, and future researchers.

6.2.1 Recommendation for Businesses and Marketers

Based on the findings, businesses should prioritize influencer credibility when implementing marketing strategies. Specifically, influencer expertise and trustworthiness were found to significantly influence brand trust and brand attitude, which subsequently affect purchase intention.

Therefore, companies are advised to collaborate with influencers who possess strong knowledge and credibility rather than focusing solely on attractiveness. This recommendation is supported by Ohanian, who emphasized that expertise and trustworthiness are critical dimensions of source credibility that influence consumer responses.

In addition, businesses should focus on building strong brand trust and positive brand attitude through transparent communication, consistent product quality, and authentic influencer endorsements. As suggested by Tang, both trust and attitude are key determinants of consumer purchase intention.

6.2.2 Recommendation for Influencers and Content Creators

The findings indicate that influencer expertise plays a significant role in shaping consumer perceptions. Therefore, influencers should focus on creating informative and value-driven content rather than relying solely on physical attractiveness.

Content such as product reviews, tutorials, and detailed explanations can enhance consumers' understanding and confidence in the product. This is consistent with Thomas et al. (2022), who found that informative content improves message effectiveness and consumer evaluation.

Furthermore, influencers should maintain authenticity and honesty in their content, as trustworthiness was found to be a key factor influencing brand trust. Building long-term credibility is more beneficial than short-term promotional gains.

6.2.3 Recommendation for Cross-Border E-commerce Platforms

Although uncertainty avoidance was not found to be significant, cross-border e-commerce platforms should still enhance user experience to reduce perceived risks and improve consumer confidence.

Platforms should focus on improving payment security, delivery reliability, product transparency, and customer service. According to Hofstede, consumers with higher uncertainty avoidance tend to be more sensitive to risk, and reducing uncertainty can improve overall consumer satisfaction.

By providing a secure and user-friendly environment, platforms can indirectly strengthen brand trust and encourage purchase intention.

6.2.4 Recommendation for Future Researchers

Future research is encouraged to expand the scope of this study by including additional variables such as price, product quality, social influence, and perceived risk, which may also influence consumer purchase intention.

In addition, future studies may consider using a larger and more diverse sample to improve generalizability. Longitudinal research designs can also be adopted to examine changes in consumer behavior over time.

Furthermore, future researchers may explore different cultural or geographical contexts to better understand the role of cultural dimensions such as uncertainty avoidance in influencing consumer behavior.

6.3 Research Limitations

Despite the contributions of this study, several limitations should be acknowledged.

First, this study is limited by its sample size and demographic distribution. The majority of respondents were young consumers, which may limit the generalizability of the findings to other age groups. Future research is recommended to include a more diverse sample in terms of age, income level, and background to improve the representativeness of the results.

Second, this study focused on selected variables, including influencer characteristics, brand trust, brand attitude, and purchase intention. Other potentially important factors such as price, product quality, perceived risk, and social influence

were not included in the model. Future studies are encouraged to incorporate additional variables to provide a more comprehensive understanding of consumer behavior.

Third, the data were collected using a self-administered questionnaire, which may be subject to response bias. Respondents may provide socially desirable answers rather than their true opinions. Future research may consider adopting mixed methods, such as combining quantitative surveys with qualitative interviews, to enhance the accuracy of the findings.

Furthermore, this study adopted a cross-sectional research design, which captures data at a single point in time and limits the ability to observe changes in consumer behavior over time. Future research may employ longitudinal approaches to better examine causal relationships and behavioral changes.

Finally, this study was conducted within the context of Chinese cross-border e-commerce brands, which may limit the applicability of the findings to other countries or industries. Future researchers are encouraged to replicate this study in different cultural or geographical settings to enhance the generalizability of the results.

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